



FROM ADAMREFLECTS.IE

The Claude *Field Guide*

What to use, when to use it, and why — no waffle.
A field guide for people learning how to get the most out of Claude.

WHAT YOU'LL LEARN

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| 1 | Models | Which brain to use for which job |
| 2 | Effort Levels | How hard Claude thinks before answering |
| 3 | Plans & Usage | What you pay, what drains usage, token guide |
| 4 | Chat vs Cowork vs Code | Three surfaces, three different jobs |
| 5 | Projects | Persistent workspaces with memory |
| 6 | Artifacts | What Claude builds for you |
| 7 | Automation | Scheduled tasks & dispatch |
| 8 | The Cheat Sheet | Every model × every effort level, with examples |

WHAT'S A TOKEN

A token is roughly $\frac{3}{4}$ of a word. A short email = ~200–400 tokens. A full A4 page = ~500–700 tokens. A 10-page report = ~5,000–7,000 tokens. Claude reads your message (input tokens) and writes a reply (output tokens) — both count toward your usage. At higher effort levels, invisible "thinking tokens" are used too.

1. Models — Which Brain to Use

Think of these as four levels of expertise. **Start with Sonnet 5 for everyday work.** Step up to Opus 5 when you need serious analysis. Fable 5 is rarely needed by most people.

Model	Price/MTok	Context	Tier	Best for	Skip when
Haiku 4.5	~€0.90 / €4.50	200K	Budget	Quick questions, translations, formatting, tagging, simple lookups	Complex reasoning, long documents, hard coding
Sonnet 5	~€1.80 / €9*	1M	Default	Everyday writing, analysis, research — 80–90% of everything	Only the hardest problems where Opus genuinely does better
Opus 5	~€4.50 / €22.50	1M	Flagship (New)	Complex analysis, dense contracts, deep debugging. Near-Fable capability at half the cost.	Simple questions — overkill
Fable 5	~€9 / €45	1M	Top Tier	The absolute hardest work. State-of-the-art.	Anything Opus 5 handles. 2× cost — rarely needed.

* Sonnet 5 intro pricing through Aug 31, 2026. Prices billed in USD; euro approximate.

2. Effort Levels — How Hard Claude Thinks

The model is *who* you hired. Effort is *how long you let them think*. Slider is next to the model selector. Default is High.

Level	Thinking Tokens	Speed	Usage Cost	When to use	Examples
Low	~1K tokens	Fastest	Lowest	Simple obvious answers	"Fix this typo" · "What's 15% of 340?"
Medium	~2-5K tokens	Fast	Moderate	Some judgment — writing, summaries	"Write a thank-you email" · "Summarise this"
High (Default)	~8-16K tokens	Moderate	Higher	Complex reasoning, multi-step work	"Plan a 2-week holiday" · "Debug this"
Max	Up to 100K+	Slowest	Highest (up to 10× Low)	Genuinely hard: contracts, architecture, deep analysis	"Analyse this contract" · "Design a business model"

Key: Max effort can use 10× more of your plan than the same question at Low. Don't leave it on Max for casual chat.

3. Plans & What Drains Your Usage

Your plan resets every 5 hours. Think of it like mobile data — some things drain it fast, others barely register.

Plan	Price	Who it's for	Rough Usage*
Free	€0	Limited Sonnet messages. Good for trying Claude.	~15-40 short msgs / 5-hr window
Pro	~€18/mo	All models, Cowork, Projects, search, memory. Opus 5 available.	~45-80 msgs or ~300K-500K input tokens / 5-hr window on Sonnet
Max 5×	~€90/mo	5× Pro usage. Opus 5 is default here.	~225-400 msgs / window on Sonnet
Max 20×	~€180/mo	20× Pro. Power users.	~22M+ Sonnet tokens/mo equivalent

* Anthropic doesn't publish exact quotas. Numbers are community estimates — check Settings > Usage for real allowance. USD-billed; euro approximate.

What drains usage fastest?

Very High: Bigger model (Fable > Opus > Sonnet > Haiku)

Very High: Higher effort level (Max vs Low)

High: Long conversations (msg 50 costs far more than msg 5)

High: Research mode / deep research

Moderate: Large files uploaded

Low: Web search

Saves usage: Starting a fresh chat

Usage credits: *Hit your limit? Enable usage credits in Settings > Usage — pay-as-you-go with a monthly cap you control.*

4. Chat vs Cowork vs Code

Three surfaces, three jobs. Same models — the difference is what Claude can access and do.

Chat

The conversation interface on [claude.ai](#) or the app. Can search the web, create files, build tools, connect to apps.

Use for: Questions, writing, research, documents, advice, learning.

Not for: Multi-step file work on your computer, automated recurring tasks.

Cowork

Claude as a desktop coworker. Reads/writes files autonomously. Runs scheduled tasks. Builds live dashboards.

Use for: Delegating work: file processing, reports, dashboards, automation.

Not for: Quick questions — Chat is faster.

Code

Terminal-based coding agent for developers. Sees your codebase, writes code, runs commands.

Use for: Professional software development.

Not for: Non-coding tasks — if you're not in a terminal, skip this.

5. Projects — Persistent Workspaces

A Project groups files, instructions, and conversations. Every new chat in a project starts with full context — no re-explaining. **Use for:** recurring topics with stable context (business brand guide, a course, a client, a hobby project, wedding planning). **Don't use for:** one-off questions — regular chat with memory is simpler.

***Projects vs Memory:** Memory remembers things about you across all chats. Projects remember things about a topic — only within that project. Use both.*

6. Artifacts vs Live Artifacts

Standard Artifact: A rendered thing Claude builds in a side panel — a document, app, chart, calculator, CV, game. It's a snapshot you iterate on in conversation. Can be shared via link (no Claude account needed to view). Examples: budget tracker, formatted report, interactive quiz, comparison chart.

Live Artifact: A persistent dashboard that **refreshes with current data** every time you open it. Built in Cowork. Pulls from connected apps (Gmail, Shopify, Calendar). Standard artifacts are frozen snapshots; live artifacts show today's data today. Desktop-app only.

7. Scheduled Tasks & Dispatch

Scheduled Tasks: Set a task to run automatically at a set time (morning email digest at 7:30am, weekly sales summary, daily brief). Results waiting when you arrive.

Dispatch: Remote trigger from your phone → fires into a Cowork session on your computer. Same files, same context. Laptop must be awake. Think: Scheduled = timer. Dispatch = button.

Routines: Cloud-hosted automation that runs even when your laptop is off. Good for 24/7 tasks.

8. The Cheat Sheet

Every model at every effort level, with real examples of when to use each combination. Italic cells = that combo is inefficient; pick a better fit.

Model	Effort	When to use it — with examples
Haiku 4.5	Low	"What's the capital of Peru?" · "Convert 50°F to C" · "Translate 'hello' to Italian"
	Medium	"Summarise this short article in 3 bullets" · "Tag these 20 emails as urgent or not" · "Format this list as a clean table"
	High	<i>Rarely needed — step up to Sonnet if you need High effort. Haiku isn't built for deep thinking.</i>
	Max	<i>Don't. Max effort on a budget model wastes both time and usage. Step up to Sonnet or Opus.</i>
Sonnet 5	Low	"What's a good pun about coffee?" · "Suggest a name for my cat" · "What time is it in Sydney?"
	Medium	"Write a thank-you email to my landlord" · "Rewrite my CV bullet points" · "Suggest 10 birthday gifts for a 12-year-old"
	High	"Plan a 5-day trip to Portugal with a €1500 budget" · "Write a 1000-word blog post on sustainable fashion" · "Help me negotiate my salary"
	Max	"Draft a full business plan for my café idea" · "Debug why this Firestore query fails intermittently" · "Design a marketing strategy for a launch"
Opus 5	Low	<i>Rarely worth it — Sonnet Low handles simple tasks just as well at lower cost.</i>
	Medium	"Read this 30-page report and give me the key findings" · "Compare these 3 vendor proposals" · "Rewrite this legal clause more clearly"
	High	"Analyse this rental lease for anything to worry about" · "Review my full business strategy and stress-test it" · "Explain this dense scientific paper"
	Max	"Review this 80-page contract and flag all risks" · "Compare 10 mortgage offers with full financial modelling" · "Design a complete database schema"
Fable 5	Low	<i>Don't. You're paying premium for a task that doesn't need it.</i>
	Medium	<i>Rarely needed. Opus 5 Medium is nearly always sufficient.</i>
	High	"Coordinate a multi-source competitive intelligence report" · "Untangle a complex family estate situation" · "Deep due diligence on an acquisition"
	Max	"Solve this novel research problem from scratch" · "Multi-agent analysis of an entire codebase" · The hardest, highest-stakes work.

The Simple Decision Tree

- 1. Quick, simple question? → **Haiku or Sonnet + Low effort**
- 2. Writing, planning, or moderate thinking? → **Sonnet + Medium effort**
- 3. Detailed work (long writing, strategy)? → **Sonnet + High effort (default)**
- 4. Sonnet not cutting it? → **Step up to Opus 5**
- 5. Hardest, highest-stakes problem? → **Opus 5 + Max effort (Fable rarely needed)**
- 6. Should it happen automatically? → **Cowork + Scheduled Task**
- 7. Need a dashboard that stays current? → **Cowork + Live Artifact**
- 8. Recurring work with stable context? → **Put it in a Project**

A field guide for people learning how to get the most out of Claude.